foreword by eric schlosser

Some wonderful chefs have donated their favorite soup recipes to this cookbook for a simple reason. Proceeds from the book will support the work of the Soil Association, a nonprofit based in Bristol, England. Few Americans have heard of the Soil Association. But almost everyone has heard of organic food and sustainable agriculture, two of the causes that the Soil Association has been promoting for more than 60 years. Indeed, the modern organic movement was launched during the 1940s by a pair of British iconoclasts, Lady Eve Balfour and Sir Albert Howard. At a time when herbicides and pesticides and synthetic fertilizers were first being introduced on a wide scale, Balfour and Howard began to question whether these were good things. They rebelled against a mindset that viewed the land as just one more economic commodity, to be doused with chemicals for a short-term profit. They rebelled against a mentality that worshipped technology for its own sake, that eagerly sought to control and dominate nature. They embraced a much more holistic view of how we should treat livestock, the land, and the rural communities dependent upon farming.

The "Soil Association" seems like an odd name for an organization devoted to producing food that's healthy, nutritious, and environmentally sound. But the soil plays a central role in the thinking behind sustainable agriculture—both as a literal concern and as a metaphor for the interconnectedness of all things. What you put in the soil winds up in the crops that grow in the soil, winds up in the animals that eat those crops, winds up in the people who eat those animals. And every living thing, and every one of us, ultimately returns to the soil. You cannot mistreat one of these elements without harming the others. This is a deeply humble philosophy, founded upon a reverence for nature and a skepticism about some of mankind's latest inventions. It is a belief that we must try to work